A Needle Through Time

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31901497.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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A Needle Through Time

by DeltaFell

Summary

Catra makes her own fate.

Catra woke up, shivering. It was still cold.

The cold lasted for what felt like forever. It was mostly dark here, wherever ‘here’ was. Where it wasn’t dark there was a light like stars, cold and piercing. As the light ripped through her, Catra could feel it taking with it parts of her, parts of who she was.

It stripped away at her will, tearing off chunks of her identity piece by piece. She was Catra, leader of the Horde, she would not bow. Catra could feel the corners of her self give way.

It stripped away at her memory, tearing off chunks of her identity piece by piece. She was Catra, and she would not bow. Catra could feel segments of her self fold away.

It stripped away at her, tearing off chunks of her identity piece by piece. She would not bow. She could feel core elements of her self rot into nothingness.

Eventually, all that was left of her was a name. Adora. Was it her name? Maybe, she wasn’t certain. The name gave her a sense of importance and warmth. She held onto the name with all the strength she could muster. The light pierced her mercilessly, and several times she almost lost her grip on the name. The name was hers, although it wasn’t her name. She wasn’t going to lose this one last thing, even if the effort killed her.

She opened her eyes and found herself staring at the floor of the Dreadnought once more. She quickly looked down at her own body, and found it lacking the star-speckled look of the Taken. She breathed a noticeable sigh of relief.

"No, little one, I will not Take you. Not today. My own son once made a mistake similar to yours, and so I will punish you the same way. Grab your things."

A Knight handed her a bag and her sword. As she grabbed them, she remembered something. She would not bow. She stood defiantly, bag upon her back and sword in hand.

Oryx chuckled, and swung his sword through the air, rending another wound in space. Through it, she could see chambers of glass and strange geometries.

"Oh little sister mine, come home glorious or die forgotten!" Oryx picked Catra up, and threw her through the portal.

As Catra landed, she realized she knew her own name now. She was still out of sorts, but recovering from whatever it was Oryx had done to her. It was only a matter of time before she remembered the rest- and most importantly, who Adora was.

Catra's claws dug into the soft rock wall as she climbed. Below her stood the strange mechanical sentries that guarded this place. They were unlike any bot she had seen before, stranger even than the inventions of the scientist. Her memory remained somewhat shattered, she had names, and she had faces, but she often did not have both.

There were a few exceptions, her old tormentor Shadow Weaver for one. Her memories of her torture at Shadow Weaver's hands had returned early and vividly. Perhaps it was the pain in them, perhaps the vague promises of Adora the memories left upon her mind, but she recalled these first.

Next to come was her purple-haired scientist friend. At least, Catra assumed they were friends from what she could remember. No name came with these memories, but she seemed to be pretty close to Catra. She spent most of her time building bots for the Horde, although she also cared for Emily, a seemingly sentient bot she had converted a long time ago. How long ago was it? It seemed like that happened forever ago.

Catra pulled herself into a crevice along the wall. She had been climbing it for a while, but these walls were just so incredibly tall. Catra unslung her bag from her shoulder and wedged it beside her. Tied to her bag was the sword. She couldn't remember everything, but that sword gave her a feeling of unease, and she felt strange whispers every time she touched it. She tied it to her bag, as far away from her body as possible.

Catra opened her bag. She needed to know what supplies she had with her, but she hadn't felt safe down there. From above, she could tell it was quite the maze, and she didn't want to know what

would happen if she got caught by one of those sentries. They didn't seem to look up, so she should be safe up here.

In the bag were mostly ration bars from the Horde. How on Etheria those got in there she had no idea. A few spare uniforms, and interestingly, an oblong device with an antenna sticking out and a screen on it. This definitely wasn't hers. After a few seconds of fiddling with it, Catra managed to turn it on. The messaging function was open, with someone named Bow. She didn't have that name, but she tried sending a message to them anyway. It didn't seem to work.

Playing around with it a little more, Catra came to the conclusion that this must have belonged to Sparkles. She was pretty certain that wasn't her real name, but something was better than nothing. Digging through the other functions of the device, Catra discovered that Sparkles's name was Glimmer. This was huge, she had another connection to her missing memories!

Her remaining memories of Glimmer came crashing down on her. Oh. They were bitter enemies. She knew they didn't get along that well, but from what she had, she thought maybe that was just their dynamic. Her hopes of rescue, of seeing someone else before she died shattered in an instant.

After what felt like days of climbing, Catra had finally reached the top of the maze's outer wall. Crystalline glass structures extruded from rough rock walls. Puddles of strange fluids pooled in divots in the ground, and all around her, mist closed in.

Lacking anything better to do, she picked a direction and began walking. Catra couldn't define it, not in any meaningful way, but something about this direction felt different. It felt good, yeah, good was the best way to describe it, she supposed.

Eventually as she walked, the mists in front of her cleared, and before her, Catra saw a man imprisoned in a small cell. He wore unfamiliar armor, unlike anything she had ever seen before. He held his head in his hands, looking at the floor of his cage. As she approached, the man looked up at her.

"Well you're different. Another fool trapped in the Vault, or merely a trick of the Vex?" He said.

"What? I have no idea where I am or who you are. And what the fuck is a Vex?" Catra said.

"I am Praedyth, and the prison that holds us both is known as the Vault of Glass. Make no mistake, while you might appear to be free, you are just as trapped as I."

Praedyth paused, and drew in a shuddering breath.

"The Vex built this prison, this vault, to control the time-stream so they could become the 'final-shape.'"

Catra's body trembled at the memories the phrase returned to her.

"Ah, I see you are familiar with this most dreadful philosophy," he said.

She nodded numbly.

"The Vex are, at their core, bacterial radiolaria inhabiting mechanical bodies. Their purpose is to be the last living thing in the universe, or maybe part of the universe itself. How exactly they intend to go about it is a mystery that no one really knows the answer to."

"How long have you been trapped here?" Catra asked.

"I'm not certain. Months at least, days, centuries, millennia, perhaps. Time in the vault is fluid, flowing where and when the Vex wish. It's all rather confusing," Praedyth said.

"This is a lot to take in," Catra said, sliding down along the wall of Praedyth's prison to sit next to him.

Unbeknownst to both Catra and Praedyth, a red light within Catra's bag switched to blue.

Catra was playing with Glimmer's communication device (trackpad? Tracker-something? Whatever the Rebellion called it) outside Praedyth's cell. That was another thing. She remembered the Rebellion's name now. The Rebellion and the Princess Alliance

had come back to her during one of Praedyth's stories about the Last City.

Catra sighed. She was such a damn mess these days. She could see it in how Praedyth looked at her when she told him what she remembered of her life before the Vault. She could hear it in the stories he chose to tell her, she could feel it in the very air around her.

"There is one place in this Vault that is somewhat safe from the insidious influence of the Vex, and it could, potentially, restore your memories." Praedyth said.

Catra jumped. She thought Praedyth had fallen asleep, he had been quiet for so long.

"And you didn't think to tell me about this sooner?" Catra said, glaring at him.

"I did not think you were ready to hear such information."

"And I am now?"

"No. But you won't get any more ready than you are now, so I may as well tell you, on the off chance it helps you."

“Well, where is it?”

“It is within the Gorgon’s Labyrinth - that pit you climbed out of before coming here. Be careful should you climb back down into that maze, do not let yourself be seen by the sentries within. Their power nearly destroyed me, and I had much then that you do not. The Light is a powerful thing, but even it could not save me. Do not get caught by the Vex.”

“Okay, don’t get caught, whatever. You still haven’t told me where this is, or even what it is!”

“Ah,” Praedyth touched a glove to his helmet contemplatively, “so I have not. The area of the Gorgon’s Labyrinth you can climb back down into is the shallowest end. Traverse deeper into the Labyrinth, and at its bottom you will find twin glass spires that reach and meet far above. Gazing into the facets will show you yourself. Whether you will be shown your past, alternate present, or future selves I was never able to determine. Hopefully seeing yourself, and perhaps some of your comrades, will help jog the rest of your memories.”

“Okay, I’ll be back, and I’ll try to get you out. I promise.” Catra said, before gathering her bag and heading off back towards where she came. Towards the Gorgon’s Labyrinth.

Once Praedyth thought she was out of earshot, he muttered, “No you won’t Catra, no you won’t. They only ever let someone visit with me twice, and this was the second time.”

Catra whirled around, intending to ask him what on Etheria he meant, but the mists had filled in completely behind her. She stood there for a minute, staring back towards Praedyth's cage. Eventually she turned back towards the Labyrinth, and tread onwards. She'd be back for Praedyth. She wouldn't leave anyone behind, not again.

Climbing back down into the pit was a lot harder than it had been to climb out. Keeping good footholds meant looking down regularly, and that slowed her down a lot.

Eventually, after a couple of near-misses, Catra made it back to where she had started. The entrance to the Gorgon's Labyrinth. Fortunately, she had spent quite some time while she was climbing observing the Gorgons. They moved in somewhat random patrol paths, but they never looked up. She could use that to her advantage.

The Labyrinth had many rock outcroppings scattered throughout. If Catra hopped from outcropping to outcropping, she could pass through the maze undetected by the Gorgons! Invigorated by this idea, Catra climbed the nearest outcropping and took a look around. To her right, two Gorgons patrolled that she could see, but the wall ended in some kind of closed massive metal aperture. Off to her left, however, the Labyrinth looked to continue further. Left it was, then.

Catra fixed her gaze on the nearest rock to her left, and then shifted her body to face it as well. She accelerated as best she could from the top of her outcropping, and leaped into the air. For one blissful second she felt weightless, before crashing down into the rock.

Catra looked around for another rock within jumping distance, but she couldn't really find any. There was a small one, big enough to hide behind, but too short to really keep her above the Gorgons' line of sight, and still too far from any bigger outcroppings. She would have to brave the ground in order to make it any further.

Catra sat for some time atop the rock, observing the patrol routes and times of the nearby Gorgons. If she was going to make a run for it - and she was, the chance to retrieve her memories was just too great to ignore - she wanted to make certain she knew those patterns by heart.

Catra counted in her head, one leg bent in front, the other extended partially behind her, ready to sprint. After a Gorgon passed her hiding place, she had to wait ten seconds before she could safely leave, and then she had five seconds to sprint across the distance before another Gorgon would swing into view.

Eight, nine, ten! Catra took off sprinting, headed straight for the other rock.

In front of Catra, two glass pillars rose far above her head and eventually met. These pillars weren't round, but instead were composed of many different sides. Catra noticed that there were some steps leading up to these pillars.

Apprehensive, she approached the pillars slowly. As she walked up the steps, Catra had an odd feeling, like these steps were made for her, and just for her. The sooner she could get her memories back and get out of here, the better.

As she got close enough, Catra began to see herself reflected in the facets of the pillars. One reflection stood out to her, drawing her in.

She stood strong upon an alien world. Her sword in hand, she commanded her Knights to charge the enemy fortification. They took their Acolytes, and they took their Thralls. Beside her, her Wizards constructed impossible deaths to slay the enemy with. Catra shivered, as her soldiers tithed portions of their kills to her. It was good to be the witch queen.

Catra shook her head as she came back to herself. That reflection held nothing for her. The future it offered was tempting, but did nothing to fill the gaps within her mind. Catra steeled herself and looked at another reflection.

She stood in a dropship, her squad there with her. She knew behind her the rest of the legion was flying in behind her. She was Primus Catra, and she would see the Skyburners victorious this day. No Rebellion would stop the Empire.

Catra sat down, shaking. If these reflections were, as Praedyth said, her future, she wasn't certain she wanted to be around to see it. After a brief reprieve, she stood back up. She had to keep trying to remember. A new reflection drew her attention, all soft colors contrasting the harsh colors surrounding it.

She stood at one end of a battlefield. She still wore her old horde uniform, but Glimmer had given her something, a sort of shoulder-cape to make it more princess-y. Catra chuckled to herself. Her, a princess, man who would've thought. Certainly she never would've, growing up in the Horde. But here she was, helping the Princess Alliance. Glimmer and Bow stepped up beside her suddenly, and Catra was confused for a minute. But as she looked around, she saw why they stepped up beside her. The Horde's strongest warrior - and if the rumors were to be believed - their new leader. She was clad in all black armor, only the blonde ponytail flowing from behind the helmet to indicate that there was even a person inside that armor at all.

As Catra recovered from the reflection, she noticed tears running down her face. Why was she crying? Catra took a deep breath and let herself sob. Eventually, she could stop her chest from heaving, and she dried her face. That reflection was the closest she'd been to recovering her lost memories, she just knew it. Catra looked at yet another reflection.

Catra looked up from the tracks. They were a week old, at most. It was rainy in the EDZ quite often, and most tracks didn't last much longer than two. She stood up, and looked back at the refugees she was leading. Scorpia was keeping a watchful eye on them while she inspected the route. Looked like Scorpia had picked up some new refugees in the interim. She pulled out the

photo from her vest pocket and unfolded it. In the photo, a young woman in her early twenties with long blonde hair held back by a tiara, and grey eyes smiled as she hugged Catra. She was wearing a long gold and white dress that reached out of the picture. Catra scanned the faces of the new refugees, comparing each one to the photo. A few people came kinda close, but none of them were the woman in her picture.

Oh. After all the searching, after all the fruitless attempts to remember, this is it? Adora most certainly hates her. Adora's never going to reciprocate her feelings, not after everything she did to her.

Something chirruped behind her. Catra spun around and opened her bag. It was Glimmer's trackerpad going off with a notification. But what kind of notification would it have? Catra turned on the trackerpad and looked at the notification, and her jaw dropped.

Hey Catra, we're coming to get you! Entrapta figured out a way for us to be able to track you using Glimmer's trackerpad, and we're taking Mara's ship- that First One's ship from the Crimson Wastes- to come and get you. Just stay where you are, we shouldn't be very far out from you!

Hugs, Bow

She could hardly believe it. She was going to get out of here! It'd started to look like she'd be stuck in the Vault forever, but this changed all of that.

Wait. They were tracking her via the trackerpad. The trackerpad that was here, with her, in the deepest part of the Gorgon's

Labyrinth. Oh shit.

Catra took off running.

Catra jumped from rock to rock like her life depended on it. It kinda did, but that wasn't why she was jumping this quickly. If she didn't get out of the Gorgons' Labyrinth in time, Adora and her princess friends would run right into the Gorgons, and be destroyed by them. She might not ever be able to have Adora the way she would like to, but if she could get out in time, then Adora would still be alive, at least. Catra could live with that.

As she got close to the exit, Catra heard the telltale sounds of princesses in danger- sparkly noises, shouts, and magic- and felt her blood run cold. She dropped to the ground and sprinted towards the noises, hoping she could do something, anything, to save Adora.

When she got there, Catra found She-Ra, stabbing her sword into a Gorgon. Around her lay the dismembered frames of several other Gorgons.

"Adora, what, how?" Catra said.

“You matter, Catra, I wasn’t going to just leave you behind. Not again, never again,” Adora said, smiling softly at her.

“Besides, you got me off that ship, Horde scum. I guess you can’t be all bad,” said Glimmer.

“Oh please Sparkles, I was just doing us both a favor,” Catra said, “but, before we go, there is one thing I have to do. Follow me guys.”

Catra led Bow, Adora and Glimmer out of the Labyrinth and back towards Praedyth’s cage. If Adora was able to beat the Gorgons, if She-Ra was that strong, then maybe, maybe, she’d be able to do one more good thing with her life.

When they got there, however, Praedyth wasn’t in the cage anymore. All that remained of him was a long dead skeleton, dry and dusty, as if it had lain there for years, and as if Catra hadn’t just seen him. Scratched into the dirt of the floor was a note.

Catra,

I don’t know how long it’s been for you since you saw me last, but it’s been a very long time for me. I knew, when you went to recover your memories, that I would never see you again. Don’t be sad for me, my time to go has long passed. Live, for yourself, and for this girl you cannot quite remember. I am now paying the

price for a mistake I made a long time ago. Get out of here while you can, and don’t look back. In this vault, time frays, and a needle passes through it. Escape before the needle can catch up to you.

Sincerely, Praedyth.

Catra’s shoulders shook. No, it couldn’t be, she just saw him. There hadn’t been enough time for any of this. She just wanted to do one more good thing. Why didn’t she get the chance to help him? What did she do wrong?

Adora kneeled next to Catra, one arm around her. Catra leaned into the one-armed hug. Adora wrapped another arm around her.

“Let’s go home, Catra,” she said.

Catra nodded weakly. Adora scooped her up, and Catra curled up against Adora.

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